market for workers from the new member states, seems to be taking its toll. To these one should add the protracted political and legal battles over the issue of freedom of movement of services (notably haulage) and over the payment of social benefits to family members of EU expat workers not residing with the working person, where Austria took the lead (and had in 2022 to accept a defeat after a long legal wrangling). And, after all, there is near total agreement that the perception of Eastern European workers in the UK greatly contributed to Brexit or was badly misrepresented by those in favour of Brexit.

The Western Balkans became the main victims of this enlargement fatigue, which, as it now seems, can only be healed with the geopolitical argument: the concern about the rise of authoritarian Russia and China, which have been making inroads into the Western Balkans too. Think, for example, of the failed project of the Chinese-built motorway in Montenegro that put the country on the verge of a default.[28] This argument was further strengthened by the case of Ukraine, but here the EU acted in a bold way and granted the victim of the Russian attack a candidate status in June of 2022. The truth is that reunification of the continent through enlargement of the EU – if sold to the public with political vision and courage – represents the best future that Europe could have and the only one that can give it lasting security.

As for World War I, its victors denied Austria-Hungary its ambitions to expand further south-east, but allowed Serbia to extend its influence further north-west. The Germanic drive towards the Adriatic was halted, but not everyone was happy or too hopeful about the prospects of the new Yugoslav state either. I will look at this period of restoration and relative prosperity in the Balkans and the wider Eastern Europe in the subsequent chapter. Before that I wish to look more closely at why Germany and Austria, once the two key players in Eastern Europe and the main actors in two world wars, lost their position of influence, and how that affected Eastern Europe.

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21. Serbs find it difficult to comprehend that Bulgaria and Romania, for example, are already EU members, but they are not (yet). From the point of view of the general level of development, the feelings of the Serbs are justified. In 1990, before the war started in former Yugoslavia, the GDP of what was then Serbia/Montenegro was USD 5,249. In the same year, the GDP of Bulgaria was USD 5,597 and that of Romania USD 3,511. Figures are from Maddison, p. 101 and 105. To this purely economic comparison one should add the fact that, after World War II, Serbia was much more open